

Primary Source Reading 1: Desire, and the Denial of the Highest Good

Optima Academy Online / Philosophy & Ethics / High School Honors (9–12) From Thomas Hobbes, Leviathan, Chapters VI and XI (1651) — text unaltered, original spelling preserved Read before Lesson 16a: Hobbes and the Political Problem

Before you read: Before Hobbes can describe political life, he has to describe human nature — and he starts somewhere unexpected: with the mechanics of wanting things. As you read, notice two moves. First, Hobbes makes “good” and “evil” relative to each person’s own desire rather than fixed features of the world. Second, he denies outright that human life aims at any final, complete satisfaction — the very possibility Aristotle’s Function Argument depended on.

Good and Evil Are Relative to Desire

But whatsoever is the object of any mans Appetite or Desire; that is it, which he for his part calleth Good: And the object of his Hate, and Aversion, evill; And of his contempt, Vile, and Inconsiderable. For these words of Good, evill, and Contemptible, are ever used with relation to the person that useth them: There being nothing simply and absolutely so; nor any common Rule of Good and evill, to be taken from the nature of the objects themselves; but from the Person of the man (where there is no Common-wealth;) or, (in a Common-wealth,) From the Person that representeth it; or from an Arbitrator or Judge, whom men disagreeing shall by consent set up, and make his sentence the Rule thereof. (*ch. VI*)

There Is No Utmost Aim

The Felicity of this life, consisteth not in the repose of a mind satisfied. For there is no such *Finis Ultimus*, (utmost ayme,) nor *Summum Bonum*, (greatest good,) as is spoken of in the Books of the old Morall Philosophers. Nor can a man any more live, whose Desires are at an end, than he, whose Senses and Imaginations are at a stand. Felicity is a continuall progresse of the desire, from one object to another; the attaining of the former, being still but the way to the later. The cause whereof is, That the object of mans desire, is not to enjoy once onely, and for one instant of time; but to assure for ever, the way of his future desire. And therefore the voluntary actions, and inclinations of all men, tend, not only to the procuring, but also to the assuring of a contented life; and differ onely in the way. (*ch. XI*)

After you read: Set this next to Aristotle’s Function Argument from Week 15. Aristotle argued that human life has a distinctive activity, and that flourishing is the excellent, complete exercise of it “in a complete life” — implying an achievable end state. Hobbes denies there is any such end state at all: desire simply moves from object to object, forever. If Hobbes is right, an entire tradition of political philosophy — one built on a shared vision of the good life —

loses its foundation. As you read the lesson, ask what politics could still be grounded in in its place.